

Lighting the Storm

An apprentice keeper repairs a failing tower, lets two storm-battered sailors in for shelter, and crosses a worsening sea for the one part that can't be fixed on site, before a passenger ship is lost on the rocks.

By **Paul** 1 Oct 2026 · post-review First-person · single-player · PC (Steam)
Bracken Isle Light · Fl(2) W 15s

PART 1

Executive Summary

You are the new apprentice to Ted, keeper of the lighthouse on Bracken Isle. You repair the building's failing systems under his direction, but the beacon keeps flickering. Two sailors, Jeff and Daniel, moor their rowboat on the island, overwhelmed by the storm. Ted sees them from the window and sends you to open the island gate. With Jeff, who wants to save the passenger ship, you cross in an engine boat to fetch a replacement burner from an abandoned outpost, then race back to fit it before the ship reaches the rocks. The core skill is **steering a powered boat past rocks and hazards as the storm worsens**. No combat, monster or jump scares; folk-horror details stay unexplained.

Design pillars

1 · The light must return

Everything leads back to the beacon: what you repair, what guides you home, what decides the ship's fate.

Test: does it connect to getting the light back?

2 · The storm sets the clock

Pressure comes from the ship's lights, weather and visibility, never a timer, meter or enemy.

Test: can the player feel time running out without UI?

3 · Your hands, your eyes

All first-person and physical. Guidance comes from Ted and Jeff, not markers.

Test: is it happening to the player, or shown to them?

4 · Dread you can read

Sustained unease, but the player always knows what to do and is told why they failed.

Test: does it add unease without confusion?

Scope rule: one lighthouse, one stretch of sea, one abandoned outpost; no new major locations.

Cast

The Apprentice (player), characterised through action and a handwritten journal. **Ted**, the gruff keeper who directs repairs, names the ship at boarding and waits at the lamp (voice only; locked by week 3). **Jeff**, a coarse older seaman and companion on both crossings, who wants to stop the ship being wrecked. **Daniel**, a younger sailor, shaken and glad to be alive, who shelters in the basement. The apprentice never speaks.

Scope

	Prototype	Full game
Length	About 10 minutes	About 30 minutes
Content	Two repairs, island gate, both crossings, burner, win and fail	All repairs, discoveries, lighter outpost set
Quality	Greybox art, placeholder audio	Final art, audio, dialogue, controller support
Time	6 weeks, solo, AI-assisted	A further 5–6 months (estimate)
Proves	Hazards readable; steering enjoyable; a fail restarts the slice	Commercial release on Steam

Stretch goal: waves that push the boat; added after the week-2 test, cut first.

Game Mechanics

One worsening night on duty, played once through the main story.

Core loop

- 01

Repair the lighthouse. Ted names the broken system; the player finds and fixes it. The beacon still flickers.
- 02

See the sailors, open the gate. Ted spots their moored boat from the window; Jeff and Daniel walk in on their own.
- 03

Board with Jeff. Ted names the ship; no deadline yet.
- 04

Cross to the outpost, steering past rocks and debris to Jeff’s calls.
- 05

Pick up the burner at the outpost.
- 06

Cross back as the storm peaks. The deadline starts here.
- 07

Fit the burner in the lamp room, where Ted waits, as the ship closes in.
- 08

Win: the ship sails into port. **Fail:** it crashes into the island.

Lighthouse repairs

Interdependent systems (lamp and optic, rotation clockwork, fuel and fog signal, stormproofing) are fixed through short first-person puzzles with a fixed toolkit, not a crafting menu. The prototype has two repairs; the rest belong to Gate 2 and the full game. The core folk-horror discoveries sit here, in the untimed lighthouse and island, tied to why the beacon failed. **Ted’s directions** are the first assist; their detail scales with difficulty. A handwritten journal tracks what is broken, and some repairs open new areas. When everything else works but the beacon still flickers, Ted goes to the window and sees a boat moored on the island, and that dead end becomes the inciting incident.

Sea crossing

The engine boat runs at **one fixed speed with one control: steering**. The challenge is placed hazards (rocks, reefs, buoys, debris) along a route that narrows and darkens as the storm grows; the sea moves for atmosphere only. **Jeff’s calls** are the second assist and read from the same hazard data as the world, so they never mislead. Aids: a compass, the beam when heading home, and silhouettes in low visibility. A collision takes on water, slows the boat or causes a brief capsize and recovery, all costing time. The burner can be knocked loose on the return but is never lost. Docking is automatic at the jetties. Penalty rules are deliberately loose for the prototype and reviewed for the full game.

Tension and the deadline

A countdown the player never sees as a number starts when the burner is aboard and the return crossing begins (the outbound crossing is free practice); Ted introduces the ship at the boarding threshold. The ship’s approaching lights and the rising storm show how much time is left. It is the only timer: it runs through the return crossing and the final repair. Mistakes cost time; only missing the deadline fails the run. Storm sound, lightning, wind and the ship’s lights follow elapsed time, while hazard density follows phase and route position, so a struggling player is not punished twice.

Act 1 · Lighthouse	Act 2 · Outbound	Act 3 · Return	Climax · Burner
Calm, tutorialised, no deadline	Moderate hazards, no deadline yet	Severe: hardest skill test	Multi-step repair on the same deadline

When the deadline expires: the foghorn sounds, the ship crashes into the island, silence, then a “Failed” title screen with a short reason. No fail before the return crossing; then, on the return crossing and stairs it is heard, not seen; from the lamp room it is seen and heard. Ted reacts by voice. In the prototype a fail restarts the slice.

Difficulty, accessibility and presentation

One difficulty preset sets how specific Ted and Jeff are and how intense hazards feel, without changing the story. Calls and the audio-only fail cue are subtitled; controls are remappable. Everything is first-person, with no cutaways. Warm lamplight plays against blue-grey storm light, the beacon’s beam is the constant visual anchor, and sound is diegetic: wind, rain, machinery, a distant foghorn, no shock stingers.

AI Architecture

One developer works with ten AI worker roles, each owning one department, overseen by two orchestrators. Each worker is described by what the player experiences as a result of its work.

AI is used during development only. The shipped game makes no AI calls: dialogue, storm and ship are authored and scripted, so there is no runtime API cost or dependency.

Agent	What the player experiences	What it builds	Human review gate
Boat / Physics	How the boat answers the stick, how clearly collisions register, how fast they recover	Fixed-speed controller, collisions, tuning data; stretch wave layer	Developer's week-2 go/no-go on feel
Level Layout	Where they can go and see: the tower climb, the moored-boat window, the island gate, the sea route, the lamp-room view of the ship	Greybox scenes, anchors, sightlines	Traversal and sightline checks
Gameplay / Systems	The story in the right order, the deadline starting on the return crossing, fair penalties, one clear ending per attempt	Phase controller, save state, repairs, deadline, win/fail	10-minute slice with no dead ends
Hazard Forecast	Jeff's calls always match the real threat	Shared hazard forecast with one safe-route signal	Jeff and the world never disagree
Story / Fail-State	A fail they can see or hear, and the reason why; the ship named at boarding; Ted at the lamp	Fail presentation, ship reveal, Ted's lamp staging	Fail reason understood from every location
Lighting	The beacon as goal and guide; darkness that deepens while hazards stay readable	Beacon sweep, visibility presets	Beacon and hazards legible every phase
Sound	A storm they can hear worsening; Jeff audible above it; no stingers	Layered storm, state-based mix	Jeff audible at peak storm
Asset	Objects they handle; unsettling symbols and shrines	Props and set dressing with provenance	Clean import; fits reference sheet
Dialogue	Ted's directions, Jeff's calls and journal objectives: how they know what to do without markers	Lines, subtitles, difficulty variants as data	Voice and lore approved before recording
QA	A night with no dead ends, both outcomes reachable	Scenario list, bug reports	Developer reproduces findings

How the agents work

- **Bounded briefs:** goal, inputs, owned files, interfaces, acceptance checks.
- **Human judgement:** the developer owns feel, tone, art fit and story, and merges every change.
- **Pillars bind every agent:** work that fails a pillar's test is returned. Unresolved story choices are escalated, never decided silently.
- **Orchestrators:** a Production Orchestrator turns goals into briefs, delegates and holds the contracts; a Canon and Review Orchestrator checks handoffs against the pillars and decisions log. They escalate canon questions and never merge.
- **Sequence:** developer settles decisions (Ted locked by week 3) → Boat/Physics and Hazard Forecast steering spike (other content waits) → Layout and Systems slice → Lighting and Sound feedback → Story/Fail-State, Dialogue and Asset content → QA and playtests.
- **Handoffs** return Godot text files, JSON data with stable IDs and a fixed-heading HANDOFF.md (files, tests, observed, not verified, licences, contract changes). Orchestrators report in REPORT.md.

Technical Strategy

Engine, build contract, schedule, token budget and constraints.

Engine: Godot 4 (confirmed)

Factor	Godot 4	Unity	Unreal 5	Phaser
First-person 3D	Good	Very good	Excellent	No (2D)
AI can edit scenes	Yes (text)	Partly	No (Blueprints)	Yes
Iteration	Fast	Medium	Slow	Fastest
Licence	Free, MIT	Free below threshold	Royalty above threshold	Free, MIT

Godot’s main gap, no built-in ocean, is off the critical path with waves as a stretch goal. Unity was the alternative; Unreal shuts out AI help; Phaser can’t meet pillar 3.

Build contract

- Separately owned scenes (lighthouse, sea, outpost, player) and one game-state controller; content stored as data with stable IDs.
- Phases: REPAIRS → SHELTER_AND_GATE → BOARDING → OUTBOUND → OUTPOST → RETURN → FINAL_REPAIR → WIN | FAIL
- Invariants: no deadline before the return crossing; Jeff is the only companion; the outcome resolves exactly once per attempt. “Unlocked routes” is dropped from the save contract.
- Weather has two channels: perception follows elapsed time, hazards follow phase and position. Gate 1 restarts the slice on a fail; Gate 2 settles a snapshot that restores time and weather together.
- Audio, UI and dialogue react to events and never change progression. Hazards, boat reaction and Jeff’s calls share one hazard forecast.

Six-week prototype schedule

Wk	Focus	Exit test
1	Setup; fixed-speed boat, one steering axis; greybox sea and hazards	Boat steers and collides reliably
2	Steering feel, hazard readability, collision recovery, hazard forecast (Gate 0)	Go/no-go: steering is fun on its own
3	Outpost pickup, harder return, storm visibility, docking	Both crossings playable; Ted locked
4	First repair, window and gate, Jeff and his calls, return-crossing clock trigger, first tuning pass	Full 10-minute path playable and tested by an outsider
5	Second repair, hidden deadline, fail-state presentation, Ted’s lamp lines, placeholder audio	Both outcomes reachable; fail reason shown
6	Playtests with 3–5 new players, tuning, tester build (Gate 1)	Prototype checks pass

Week 5 is heavily loaded; if it slips, the developer decides what gives. Later gates: 2 · Narrative alpha (all repairs, discoveries, dialogue, final retry and save model); 3 · Content and polish (final art, audio, accessibility, 30-minute pacing). Waves start only after Gate 0 passes, sit behind an on/off setting, and are cut first.

Token Budget, Constraints and Feasibility

Token budget

Unit: one agent task of about 40 turns at a 60K-token context, roughly 2.4M input tokens (about 90% cache reads) and 40K output. Mix: Opus 5.5 for implementation (70%), Sonnet 5 for routine work (20%), Haiku 4.5 for search and formatting (10%).

~\$500 Prototype · ~250 tasks · range \$250–\$1,400	~\$2,050 Full game incl. prototype · ~835 tasks · range \$1,000–\$5,000	~20M Input tokens a day in the prototype, mostly cached
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Model	Input / MTok	Output / MTok	Cache read	Per task
Claude Opus 5.5	\$4.00	\$20.00	\$0.20	\$2.36
Claude Sonnet 5	\$2.00	\$10.00	\$0.20	\$1.40
Claude Haiku 4.5	\$1.00	\$5.00	\$0.10	\$0.70

Excludes other vendors’ AI art, audio and voice tools, paid engine assets and the Steam fee. Usage is re-measured after week 1. Figures are not yet re-baselined for the post-review changes (second repair, fail-state work, orchestrators).

API and plan constraints

- **Plan limits:** a Claude Team plan with rolling 5-hour and weekly limits and no overage, so hitting a limit pauses work. Prototype pace is estimated at 30–50% of the weekly limit.
- **Caching:** exact-prefix matching; stable docs and briefs keep most input as cheap cache reads.
- **Context:** 1M tokens on Opus 5.5 and Sonnet 5, 200K on Haiku 4.5; narrow briefs keep usage far below this.
- **Opus 5.5:** thinking is always on; spend is controlled with the effort setting.

Feasibility in 6 weeks

Target	Verdict	Why
10-min prototype	Feasible, with conditions	A playtest build, not a product. Needs steering to pass in week 2, frozen scope, placeholder assets, week 6 for playtests.
30-min full game	Not feasible	27–31 weeks solo (about 5 with stock assets). Gaps: 3D art and animation, QA, Steam launch prep.

Risks: boat feel (tested first at Gate 0), scope creep (held by the pillars) and usage limits (monitored weekly). **Key open decisions:** locking Ted by end of week 3, deadline length, the final retry and save model (before Gate 2), controller support in the prototype, which two repairs. **Beyond scope and cut list:** return-crossing route branching, companion choice, Daniel as a companion, a hidden coda, Full Gale mode.